

Recently and lately

Learner workbook

Choose a tense that fits the event, not just the adverb.

Understand the distinction

Recently means a short time ago or during the recent past. It can describe one finished event with the past simple: I recently bought a bike. It also occurs with the present perfect: I have recently changed jobs.

Lately usually describes recent states or repeated activity, often with the present perfect: I have been busy lately; I have been cycling lately. It is less usual for a single finished event. Neither word requires the present perfect continuous, and neither guarantees that an activity will continue.

Compare the patterns

ONE EVENT

I recently visited a friend.

Past simple fits a finished visit.

RECENT STATE

I have been tired lately.

Been + adjective describes a state.

REPEATED ACTIVITY

I have been walking more lately.

The continuous form highlights activity.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose for a single visit: I visited Rome ____ . (recently / lately)

- A. recent
- B. lately
- C. recently

2. Is I have been busy lately a present perfect continuous verb?

- A. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.
- B. Yes. Every phrase with have been is continuous.
- C. No. It is the past perfect.

3. Does I have been running lately guarantee future running?

- A. No. It describes recent activity.
- B. Yes. Lately always includes tomorrow.
- C. Yes. It promises the person will keep running.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair naturally describes one recent event and a recent repeated activity?

A. I recently joined a class. I have studying more lately.

B. I lately joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

C. I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. recently

Recently readily refers to a single past event.

2. A. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.

The continuous form needs an -ing main verb.

3. A. No. It describes recent activity.

Future continuation needs more context.

4. C. I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

Recently fits the single event; lately fits the recent pattern of studying.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-16.html